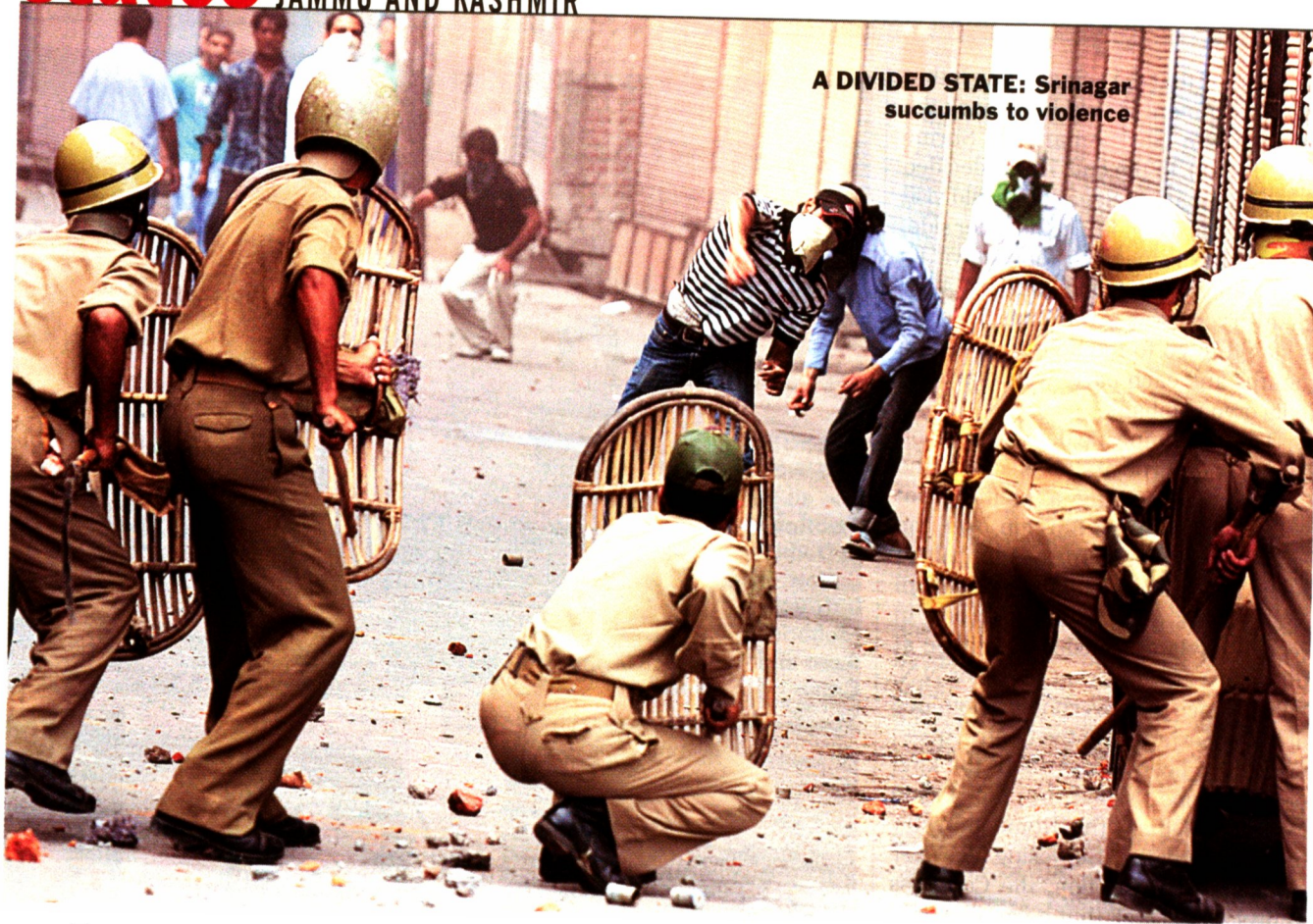




A DIVIDED STATE: Srinagar succumbs to violence

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FANNING THE FLAMES

The UPA Government's flip-flops on the Amarnath land transfer backfire as restive Hindus resort to continued violence paralysing the state's economy and turning a local issue into a national concern

■ **By Priya Sahgal and Aijaz Hussain in Srinagar**

For Congress President Sonia Gandhi, this was a first. Last week, watching Jammu slowly spin out of the Centre's control, she picked up the phone and dialled a political opponent, BJP chief Rajnath Singh. Another first followed as Sonia asked for his help in resolving what she called a sensitive issue, one of national interest. Rajnath agreed that the Amarnath shrine land

transfer was no longer a local issue but a national one. He pointed out that this was probably the first time that a benefit given to a religious cause had been withdrawn and asked the Centre to come up with a concrete proposal. Sonia was not the only one brushing up on her cross-party diplomacy. A fortnight after attacking him on the floor of the House, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh reached out to L.K. Advani and invited the leader of the Opposition over to his residence. A week later, Manmohan summoned an

all-party meeting on August 6.

Not surprisingly, the meeting was inconclusive. The Congress had simply allowed the situation to fester for too long for it to be resolved at one sitting, even though it was a marathon four-hour-long session. While Manmohan sought the BJP's help to end the economic blockade in the state called by the RSS-affiliated Amarnath Yatra Sangarsh Samiti (AYSS), the BJP retaliated saying it could not help without some sort of guarantee from the UPA over the land allotment. Privately, BJP